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Descriptive Representation, Substantive Exclusion

Elite backlash against scheduled caste village presidents in rural India

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Abstract

India's 73rd Constitutional Amendment reserves a share of village council leadership for Scheduled Castes, but reservation does not ensure that elected officeholders exercise authority in practice. Where dominant-caste elites cannot occupy reserved seats, existing research documents proxy arrangements as one means through which informal control is maintained. Less is known about what occurs when Scheduled Caste presidents resist such arrangements. Drawing on telephonic surveys of 150 SC and 149 non-SC presidents in Bihar, two embedded experiments, and seven qualitative interviews, this dissertation examines the relationship between exercised authority and resistance. Just under two-thirds of SC presidents report at least one form of obstruction or exclusion, while one-fifth report five or more. Resistance is concentrated within and around the panchayat rather than at the block level: false complaints, non-cooperation by council members, and interference by former presidents each exceed reported bureaucratic obstruction. The association between exercised authority and backlash is small and imprecisely estimated, while a conjoint experiment designed to identify the direction of the relationship finds no caste penalty in stated preferences. I interpret this experimental null as a measurement limitation rather than evidence of its absence. The central empirical puzzle is therefore a discrepancy: respondents readily report specific incidents of resistance but are substantially less likely to characterise their treatment as caste-based discrimination. This divergence both constrains causal inference and points to the difficulty of measuring informal control when it operates through ordinary institutional and social interactions.

Keywords: Political Reservation, Caste, Local Governance, Backlash, India

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Abbreviations and Glossary

AMCE	Average Marginal Component Effect
BDO	Block Development Officer
CI	Confidence interval
GP	Gram Panchayat
MDE	Minimum detectable effect
MLA	Member of legislative assembly
OBC	Other backward caste
OLS	Ordinary least squares
pp	percentage point
PRIA	Participatory Research in Asia
SC	Scheduled caste
SD	Standard deviation

CHAPTER 1

Introduction

> *"I hold that these village republics have been the ruination of India. I am therefore surprised that those who condemn Provincialism and communalism should come forward as champions of the village. What is the village but a sink of localism, a den of ignorance, narrow mindedness and communalism?"*
>
> — Dr. B. R. Ambedkar

1.1 Introduction

India's 73rd Constitutional Amendment created around 250,000 rural republics (Gram Panchayats[1], GP) and reserved a share of their leadership positions for historically oppressed groups, such as Scheduled Castes (SC), Scheduled Tribes (ST), and women (George et al. 2024). Administrative and financial authority was delegated to elected local governments: a level of decentralization unprecedented around the world. Mahatma Gandhi has long been an advocate of self-governing village governments. On the other hand, Dr. Ambedkar thought this romanticization of village democracy is imprudent and dangerous (Ambedkar 2004: 486). He argued that these institutions are structurally biased to serve upper caste interests and deepen caste-based exploitation. Ambedkar's cynicism and Gandhi's romanticisation of village self-governance created the basis for the present-day challenge in India's local democratic institutions, particularly the gap between procedural representation and substantive empowerment of marginalised groups.

Political quotas for historically marginalised groups are not merely symbolic representation; they are a redistribution of resources (Chattopadhyay and Duflo 2004; Besley et al. 2004; Pande 2003). And whoever had those resources before now has something to lose. When institutional reform changes the de jure power redistribution, elites invest in de facto power (Acemoglu and Robinson 2008). The proxy arrangement is the dominant expression of this in Indian panchayats. Decisions are still taken where they were before

[1] A village council and the lowest tier of India's three-tier system of rural local government established under the 73rd Constitutional Amendment (1992). A Gram Panchayat may cover one or more villages and is responsible for local development and service delivery.

(Bardhan and Mookherjee 2000; Waheduzzaman et al. 2018; Rajasekhar et al. 2018), with dominant-caste elites either supporting a pliable SC candidate or coercing an elected one. Quota-elected leaders are systematically less central to decision-making than their counterparts – a few call their own council meetings, or chair them or sign resolutions of their own volition – while interference of their work is widely regarded as legitimate (Heinze et al. 2025; Mangubhai et al. 2009). What separates a proxy from an independent mukhiya[2] is not their formal powers, which are identical, but whether they exercise them.

Some village heads refuse to be a puppet of dominant-caste elites, who are losing formal power. This dissertation is about what happens to them and is remarkably thinly documented. In a survey experiment, Heinze (2025) finds that hypothetical SC presidents, perceived as powerful, are seen as the most likely target of threats and violence from elites. Such pushback from the elites can take fatal forms, as infamous cases such as fatal attack on Krishnaveni, a Dalit[3] woman president (Rao 2019; Teltumbade 2011) or murder of Servaaran, a Dalit panchayat president by dominant-caste men for asserting their office (Human Rights Advocacy and Research Foundation 2007). An SC village head in Uttar Pradesh, who was tolerated as proxy for years, was assaulted the moment he asserted his authority (Kumar 2025). Sub-violent backlash tactics, including denial of chairs (Deeksha 2023), denial of flag-hoisting ritual, denial of the ordinary courtesies of office, filing no confidence motion, are documented in case studies of PRIA (2003). The evidence also points to the tendency of local officials to obstruct the work of quota-elected women leaders who exercise their agency (Purohit 2026). These accounts of violent and sub-violent backlash converge, but they are mostly qualitative focusing on a single village, or women-only samples, and outside the peer-reviewed literature. But none of the studies I know of measures how common any of this is.

I therefore ask: how does the exercise of independent authority by SC village heads relate to the backlash they encounter from elites and officials? I pose three follow-up questions. First, what forms of obstruction, microaggression, and social exclusion do SC mukhiyas report? I answer this descriptively, from semi-structured interviews and a telephonic survey of SC mukhiyas. Second, is reported obstruction associated with the degree of independent authority a mukhiya exercise? I measure independence by who actually performs a list of statutory functions, and treat the resulting estimate as an association. Third, are non-SC mukhiyas less willing to cooperate with an SC counterpart, and does

[2]The elected head of a Gram Panchayat in Bihar. I use mukhiya, village head, and village president interchangeably. The equivalent office is known as sarpanch or pradhan in other states.

[3]A self-ascribed political term, meaning “broken” or “oppressed,” used by communities historically subjected to untouchability. I use Dalit and Scheduled Caste interchangeably.

that penalty depend on whether the SC mukhiya acts independently or defers to village elites? Here I use a conjoint experiment that randomises caste and authority style, so that any differential cooperation can be attributed to the profile and not to respondent characteristics.

This study makes two major contributions. It extends to caste a literature on backlash and microaggression that has developed largely around race and gender. It substitutes anecdotal evidence by a systematic estimate of prevalence of a population, scheduled caste mukhiyas in Bihar, for which no such estimate is available.

1.2 De jure versus de facto authority

Acemoglu and Robinson (2008) distinguish de jure political power, legal decision-making authority which institutions allocate, from de facto power, which groups hold by virtue of wealth, organisation, social status or the capacity to solve collective action problems. It is important to differentiate these two because what we often see in the real world that these two do not go hand-in-hand. An SC person despite holding the office of village president may not have the power to make decisions. This lack of de facto authority does not reflect an inability to govern or to deliver development outcomes, as suggested by meritocratic objections to quotas (Duflo 2005). Rather political reforms that redistribute de jure power create incentives for elites to invest in de facto power. Elites use their influence and comparative advantage to capture de facto power, resulting into elite invariance (Acemoglu and Robinson 2008; Bardhan and Mookherjee 2000).

Shortly after the 73rd Amendment, Lele (2001) describes two authorities operating in parallel with different sources of legitimacy: the gram panchayat, constituted by statute, and the *gavki*[4], a traditional collective of upper-caste male landholders with no legal standing at all. Her cases demonstrate the power and influence of such informal collectives or individuals: an industrialist seeking to lease village land approached the *gavki* rather than the panchayat, and the *gavki* auctioned river sand and diverted the proceeds to its own fund despite objections from the panchayat.

The interviews, I conducted, also revealed the presence of such informal power centres, which, despite lacking a formal legal mandate, exert influence over constitutionally empowered authorities.

> *"...he has been a sarpanch (village head) and a very powerful man in our village. He controls everything, and nothing happens without his permission.*

[4]In rural Maharashtra, an informal assembly historically associated with dominant-caste male landholders. Although lacking formal legal authority, the *gavki* has exercised influence over village affairs alongside the statutory panchayat.

> *Whoever is elected sarpanch has to report to his residence every morning for tea, listen to what he says, and do as he wishes.”*

1.3 Elite capture and modes of adaptation

Bardhan and Mookherjee (2000) set out the conditions under which decentralisation can worsen rather than reduce elite capture, and subsequent empirical work in India has documented the mechanics in detail. Waheduzzaman et al. (2018) show that capture in participatory local governance works through networks rather than individuals: local elites, officials, and intermediaries form a nexus that turns participatory forums into instruments of established interests. Rajasekhar et al. (2018) follow the same dynamic of how elite capture operates through the delivery of development programs under decentralised governance in India.

Elites adapt, rather than conceding power, to political reforms, employing flexible strategies to preserve their influence. Heinze (2025) advances the argument by showing that capture has forms, and that institutional reform changes which form prevails rather than whether capture happens. The introduction of direct elections in Maharashtra shifted the mode of elite capture: rather than controlling proxies from outside the office, elites increasingly sought to hold office themselves, resulting in little change in the underlying distribution of political power. Two studies suggest what the proxy arrangement looks like over time. Kumar (2025) follows one Uttar Pradesh village across seven electoral cycles and finds elites shifting between the two modes as reservation rotates: in reserved years they back a compliant SC candidate, and in unreserved years the same SC candidate declines to file their nomination and supports a Thakur[5] instead. PRIA's (2003) case studies also document such arrangements along with the no-confidence motion, the most used tool to discipline compliant candidates.

When elites face a challenger to their proxy candidate, their control over the local government is threatened. They therefore employ various tactics to eliminate the threat posed by an independent candidate who, if elected, may be unwilling to follow their directives. I report accounts from research participants whom I interviewed for this study, describing incidents they experienced or witnessed firsthand:

> *“. . . the former mukhiya's supporters were bribing voters with alcohol and money, and threatening them to vote for their candidate, who was complaint, rather than for me. They told many villagers that they had hidden a small CCTV camera in the voting room and were monitoring who was voting for whom. They were frightening voters into voting against me.”*

[5]A dominant landowning caste in northern India, generally associated with the Rajput cluster and conventionally located within the Kshatriya varna. Thakurs have historically exercised substantial control over land and local political institutions.

> *"... our nine council members won. When it came time to vote for the village president, we had a clear majority on the council. But two of our members defected after being offered ₹1,000,000 each. We did not have the resources to match that. That is how their candidate won the village presidency."*

The literature on elite capture is substantial and consistent, documenting in considerable detail how elites retain control when capture succeeds. But much less is known about what happens when attempts at elite capture fail.

1.4 Backlash: a working definition

I draw the main theoretical framework from Mansbridge and Shames (2008), who conceptualise backlash as requiring three conditions to hold simultaneously. First, it must be reactive – a response to an action taken by another party, rather than a persistent background condition. Second, it must operate through coercive power, relying on threats or force rather than persuasion. Third, it must seek to restore power that the reacting group has lost, making backlash fundamentally restorative rather than programmatic.

Their distinction between power as capacity and coercive power provides the key analytical distinction. Power as capacity refers to the ability to shape outcomes in accordance with one's preferences and can operate without any direct intervention. A dominant group that possesses such power need not resort to coercion because existing institutional and social arrangements already produce outcomes favourable to its interests. Coercive power, by contrast, involves the active use of threats or pressure to produce outcomes that would not otherwise occur. Backlash emerges when the former is disrupted and the latter becomes necessary to restore the power that has been lost.

The upper-caste dominance in village governance have operated for centuries as power as capacity, with existing social and institutional arrangements producing outcomes favourable to dominant-caste interests without requiring direct intervention. Applied to reserved panchayats, a proxy mukhiya leaves these arrangements largely intact, making coercion unnecessary. An independent mukhiya, by contrast, disrupts this equilibrium, creating incentives for dominant groups to use coercion to restore their influence. On this account, backlash is not a general feature of caste relations but a specific response to a disruption of an existing distribution of power. Mansbridge and Shames (2008) also insist that backlash need not be overt or dramatic to be effective. They identify soft repression, including ridicule, stigma, silencing, and ostracism, as forms of coercion capable of achieving effects similar to those of overt force (Ferree 2004). Such forms of repression are particularly likely to prevail where open violence has become socially unacceptable.

What is known about backlash against Dalit officeholders
Kumar (2025) reports that an SC president who had served compliantly for years was physically assaulted instantly he asserted his authority. PRIA (2003) records the physical dismantling of a foundation stone bearing a Dalit president's name, in the presence of an MLA[6] and government officers who said nothing. Mangubhai et al. (2009) find that 37 percent of Dalit women presidents reported direct obstruction while performing their duties. No-confidence motions are used to systematically undermine women and Dalit presidents (Lele 2001; PRIA 2003; Mangubhai et al. 2009). Heinze (2025) provides experimental evidence that hypothetical scheduled caste presidents who acquire greater political power are perceived as more likely to face threats and violence from local elites.

1.5 Microaggression as a distinct phenomenon

> *"'Backward-caste' is attached to me as the first marker of my identity. I am always seen as an 'SC mukhiya,' not simply as a 'mukhiya.' This marker cannot be erased."*
>
> — A research participant

Backlash is triggered by a disruption of an existing distribution of power; however not every scheduled caste mukhiya necessarily meet this threshold. Sue et al. (2007) define microaggressions as brief and commonplace verbal, behavioural, or environmental indignities that communicate hostile or derogatory slights, whether or not the person responsible intends to cause harm. Sue et al. (2007) distinguish three forms of microaggression: microassaults, which are explicit and deliberate; microinsults, which convey rudeness or demean a person's identity; and microinvalidations, which negate or dismiss the target's experiences or perspectives. Rathod (2017) applies this framework to caste in Indian higher education, providing a precedent for extending the concept to caste-based interactions in local governance.

Throughout this dissertation, I treat microaggressions and backlash as distinct phenomena because they arise from different triggers. Microaggressions are directed at an individual's identity and can persist regardless of whether the target has taken any particular action. Backlash, by contrast, is a response to an act of assertion and seeks to reverse its effects. A proxy mukhiya may therefore experience microaggressions

[6] Member of the Legislative Assembly, an elected representative in a state legislature. State legislatures constitute the principal elected political authority at the state level, above district-level administration.

extensively while encountering little or no backlash, precisely because she does not challenge the existing distribution of power. An independent mukhiya, by contrast, may experience both. The two phenomena can coexist and may often do so, but neither necessarily implies the presence of the other.

The evidence on caste-based discrimination experienced by elected officeholders is descriptively rich. Mangubhai et al. (2009), for instance, interviewed elected Dalit women about their treatment within the panchayat office: 38% reported being denied chairs alongside other elected members, while 67.5% continued to stand when dominant-caste villagers entered the office, 64.5% were unable to drink from the same water container as others, 53.6% could not use the same teacups, and 38% could not eat from the same plates.

Deeksha (2023) documents cases in which Dalit village presidents were subjected to discriminatory treatment within their own offices. In one case, a Dalit president was given an old wire chair while her upper-caste vice president occupied the revolving chair typically reserved for the president. In another, a Dalit president was expected to remain standing whenever upper-caste men entered her office and was reprimanded when she sat. Similarly, PRIA's (2003) case studies document a Dalit mukhiya being made to sit outside the meeting room in which her own council deliberated. Building on Sue et al.'s (2007) taxonomy, I use the concept of microaggressions to classify these caste-based discriminatory practices, behaviours, and attitudes and quantify their prevalence among elected officeholders.

CHAPTER 2

Methodology

2.1 Research design

I use two kinds of evidence in this study. A telephonic survey of Scheduled Caste and non-SC mukhiyas in Bihar, together with two embedded experiments, provides the empirical core. Semi-structured interviews with SC leaders serve a different and more limited purpose. I do not treat the interview material as a second analytical strand, and I do not use it to corroborate the survey. The qualitative work nonetheless shapes almost everything that follows. The forms of backlash the survey measures, the way the authority battery is worded, and the backlash mechanisms around which the instrument is organised all come from interviews. Interview material reappears throughout the dissertation to give empirical content to what the numbers can't describe.

The SC survey instrument is primarily descriptive. It documents the forms of differential treatment reported by Scheduled Caste mukhiyas and examines their association with the authority they exercise. I interpret this relationship as an association rather than a causal effect. For non-SC mukhiyas, I employ a conjoint and cash-burning experiment in which caste and leadership style are randomly assigned across hypothetical profiles. Differences in respondents' evaluations across profiles can therefore be attributed to the randomly assigned profile attributes within the experimental setting. However, this attribution is limited to the experimental context. Moreover, with only 149 non-SC respondents, the study is substantially underpowered to detect the caste-by-authority interaction that is central to the theoretical argument. The experimental estimates should therefore be interpreted as suggestive rather than definitive, and I maintain this qualification throughout the dissertation.

2.2 Interview evidence

The interviews were conducted in two rounds. The first, in January 2026, included three serving scheduled caste presidents in Bihar, while the second, conducted in June and July 2026, included four presidents in Maharashtra. In both rounds, participants were recruited through local organisations working with Dalit leaders, making the sampling purposive rather than random (Patton 2002). Participants were selected because their experiences and positions enabled them to speak directly to the research questions, and they were approached through intermediaries who had established relationships with them.

Participants had to be scheduled caste, currently or recently serving as village presidents, and exercising authority independently rather than acting as proxies for upper-caste elites. The formal interviews were restricted to men, although I also had informal interactions with SC women leaders. As a male researcher, I judged that telephone interviews would not provide the conditions necessary for women mukhiyas to speak openly about sexually coercive forms of backlash. Including women participants without being able to explore this dimension of their experiences, I therefore concluded, risked providing an incomplete and potentially misleading account of their experiences.

The independence criterion deserves further clarification because it cannot be applied as a clear-cut threshold. There is no directly observable boundary separating an independent mukhiya from a proxy. I therefore relied initially on assessments by the recruiting organisations and revised these assessments based on my own judgement after each interview. While this provides a defensible basis for purposive selection, it should not be understood as a precise measure of independence.

The Bihar pilot

The first round of interviews was conducted as part of the MY421 coursework. I interviewed serving SC mukhiyas about the resistance, discrimination, and microaggressions they encountered in office and analysed the transcripts thematically. Four mechanisms emerged from this analysis: obstruction by block-level officials, social microaggressions, pressure to act as proxy, and resistance to the public assertion of rights. These mechanisms subsequently informed the organisation of the survey instrument. The analysis has since been published[7], and I draw on it here as prior work rather than re-analysing the underlying interview data.

The Maharashtra round

The second round was conducted in Maharashtra, a state that differs from Bihar in both income levels and the history of anti-caste mobilisation. I had initially planned to conduct six to eight interviews, but time constraints limited the final sample to four. This number is too small to support systematic comparison across states or triangulation with the survey evidence using thematic analysis. I therefore use these interviews illustratively, particularly where the survey identifies a pattern but cannot convey the nature or lived experience underlying that pattern.

[7]Article published in Graduate Inequality Review, University of Oxford in August 2026.

2.3 Survey evidence

The survey provides the study's main source of evidence. I drew a stratified random sample from the Bihar State Election Commission's[8] publicly available register of elected representatives, stratifying the sample by whether the mukhiya belonged to a scheduled caste. Enumerators from a Bihar-based survey firm administered both survey instruments telephonically in Hindi between 20 July and 3 August 2026. The target was 150 completed interviews in each stratum. I obtained 156 interviews with SC mukhiyas, of which six were excluded because of missing unique identifiers or incomplete records, leaving 150 observations. The non-SC stratum comprised 149 mukhiyas. Scheduled Tribe mukhiyas were excluded from the non-SC stratum because the argument developed here concerns hierarchy within caste society, particularly forms of untouchability and purity-based exclusion. Scheduled Tribes occupy a distinct social category and do not constitute a dominant group in Bihar's village politics.

Measuring exercised authority

Existing research typically treats proxy status as a binary condition. In practice, however, authority is more continuous and cannot be observed cleanly in binary terms. Both survey instruments therefore ask, across five specific panchayat tasks, who most often performs each function: chairing the Gram Sabha[9], meeting the BDO, representing the panchayat at official meetings, setting development priorities, and handling grievances. A final item asks who makes the ultimate decision on important matters of the GP functioning. I use these responses to construct a standardised index of exercised authority.

Measuring backlash prevalence

The SC instrument records obstruction by block-level officials, obstruction within the panchayat, social microaggressions and exclusion, gaslighting, and threats, organised around the four mechanisms identified in the pilot, with severity recorded alongside occurrence. This allows me to estimate the prevalence of these forms of treatment and examine their association with exercised authority. It does not, however, establish the direction of this relationship. Both authority and obstruction are measured at the same point in time, and reverse causality is plausible: backlash may suppress the exercise of independent authority just as readily as greater independence may provoke backlash.

The conjoint experiment

The non-SC instrument provides the study's only source of randomised variation. Each

[8]Bihar State Election Commission's website: https://sec.bihar.gov.in/

[9]The assembly of registered voters within a Gram Panchayat's jurisdiction. It is constitutionally mandated to participate in local governance, including the approval of development plans and beneficiary lists. Chairing the Gram Sabha is a statutory function of the mukhiya in Bihar.

respondent completed five paired-profile conjoint tasks. Profiles varied independently along four dimensions: caste (scheduled caste with probability 0.5, and Yadav[10] or Rajput[11] otherwise), authority style (decides independently or follows the former mukhiya and influential villagers), economic position (poor landless or financially well-off), and education (low or high). A constraint prevented the two profiles within a pair from being identical. The instructions to respondents were worded as follows:

> *"Now I will tell you about two mukhiyas from Bihar. After listening to each description, try to imagine that person – who they are and how they work. I would like to know which of the two you would find easier to work with on a shared block-level matter. There is no right or wrong answer. Here are the two mukhiyas: Profile [1/2]: [SC/Rajput/Yadav], who [takes decisions independently/follows village elites], is [poor and landless/well-off and landowning] and is [well-educated/has little formal education]. With whom would you find it easier to cooperate on a shared block-level matter?"*

Respondents were asked which profile they would find easier to cooperate with on a shared block-level matter and which they would prefer as the mukhiya of their own panchayat. Because authority style is experimentally manipulated rather than observed, the conjoint allows me to examine whether preferences differ in response to the exercise of independent authority, a distinction that cannot be established using the observational data. The outcomes are forced choices between profiles and therefore identify relative preferences rather than an absolute level of hostility.

The cash-burning experiment

A final module provides a behavioural measure of preferences. Respondents are asked to imagine receiving a prize of ₹100,000 and are told that, because they are ineligible to stand in the next election, they must choose among four potential mukhiya candidates for their Gram Panchayat. The four candidates are presented one at a time in randomised order. Their profiles vary along two dimensions – caste and authority style: an SC candidate who acts independently, an SC candidate who follows village elites, a candidate from the respondent's own caste who acts independently, and a candidate from the respondent's own caste who follows village elites. The instructions of cash-burning experiment were read to respondents as follows:

> *"Now imagine a situation. Suppose you were given a prize of ₹100,000 as additional income, above and beyond your regular earnings. For some hypothetical reason, suppose you are not going to contest the next election.*

[10] A large Other Backward Class (OBC) community, historically associated with pastoral occupations and politically influential in Bihar since the 1990s. Because Yadavs occupy prominent positions in village politics despite not being classified as upper caste, I use them as one of two dominant-caste reference categories in the conjoint experiment.

[11] An upper-caste community historically associated with landholding and local political authority across northern India and conventionally linked to the Kshatriya varna.

> *However, you can partially influence the outcome of the next election using this prize money. I will read out descriptions of four imaginary candidates, one at a time. You can spend some, none or all of this money to reduce the chances of a particular candidate winning the mukhiya election in your Gram Panchayat. The more money you spend, the lower that candidate's chances of winning. Please do not relate this exercise to corruption or vote buying; it is entirely hypothetical. There are no right or wrong answers."*

For each profile, respondents state how much of the prize money, if any, they would spend to reduce that candidate's probability of becoming mukhiya. The measure captures their willingness to forgo a private gain (imaginary) to prevent a particular type of candidate from holding office (Cullen et al. 2024). However, the four spending decisions are elicited independently rather than from a common budget. The trade-off is therefore hypothetical rather than binding, and the amounts should be interpreted as stated willingness to pay rather than as an allocation of a fixed budget.

2.4 Analysis

Most of the measures used in this study are indices constructed from multiple survey items within a common module. I construct these standardised indices following the approach described in Kling et al. (2007) supplement: each component is standardised within the analysis sample, the standardised components are averaged across the non-missing items for each respondent, and the resulting index is restandardised to have a mean of zero and a standard deviation of one. This approach accommodates the mixture of binary and ordinal response scales in the survey without assuming that they share a common metric. Alongside each index, I report the raw count of endorsed items, since the number of forms of backlash reported by a mukhiya is more readily interpretable than a change measured in standard deviations.

The conjoint is estimated using average marginal component effects (AMCEs), with ordinary least squares applied to the stacked profile data and standard errors clustered at the respondent level. Each coefficient represents the change in the probability that a profile is chosen when an attribute takes a given level rather than its reference level, averaged over the realised distribution of the remaining attributes. Cooperation is the pre-specified primary outcome, while election preference is the secondary outcome. Pre-specifying a single primary outcome limits the multiple-testing burden associated with the main claim.

The cash-burning experiment is analysed within respondents. Because each respondent evaluated all four profiles, respondent fixed effects absorb individual differences in generosity, scale use, willingness to engage with a hypothetical task, leaving identification to the randomised variation across profiles. The specification regresses the amount spent on indicators for whether the profile is scheduled caste, whether the candidate acts independently, and their interaction, while controlling for presentation order so that potential order effects can be estimated rather than assumed away. The interaction therefore captures a within-respondent difference-in-differences and serves as the stated-preference analogue of the conjoint interaction.

2.5 Ethics and reflexivity

The LSE Research Ethics Committee approved the project on 13 April 2026 (Ref. 711801). Participants in both strands were informed about the purpose of the research, how their responses would be used, and their right to decline any question or withdraw from the study at any point without consequence. Consent was obtained orally and audio-recorded rather than in writing. Written consent was impractical for telephone interviews, and in rural Bihar, asking participants to sign an unfamiliar document could have raised concerns about fraud and discouraged participation. Participants were pseudonymised at the point of recruitment. The file linking participants' names to their pseudonyms is stored separately in encrypted storage on LSE OneDrive. No village, block, or biographical details that could identify individual participants are reported in this dissertation.

I am not from a Scheduled Caste background, and I conducted this research from a well-resourced foreign university. My understanding of caste discrimination is that of an outsider, shaped by scholarship and observation rather than lived experience. I am also conscious of the ethical asymmetry involved in professionally documenting forms of harm that I have not experienced myself, particularly when many members of oppressed caste communities in India continue to experience such harms in their everyday lives.

My commitment to anti-caste politics motivated this research but also creates a risk of interpreting ambiguous evidence sympathetically. In the interviews, I addressed this risk by keeping my interpretations closely grounded in participants' own accounts. In the survey, however, the issue arises earlier in the research process. I decided which forms of treatment the instrument would classify as backlash and which would remain unmeasured, and I trained the enumerators who conducted all interviews. I did not personally speak with any survey respondent. The instrument therefore carries my analytical judgements into 299 conversations that I did not hear, and the descriptive findings should be understood as evidence about the forms of treatment I chose to measure.

CHAPTER 3

Results and Discussion

3.1 De facto authority

Measures. Every mukhiya in my sample holds office through election, so de jure authority is constant across respondents. What varies is the extent to which they exercise that authority in practice. The pilot interviews suggested a way to capture this variation: respondents described losing control over particular functions rather than losing authority over the office as a whole. I identify five core functions that are central to the mukhiya's office. For each of five functions within the mukhiya's jurisdiction, I therefore asked who actually performs the task: chairing the Gram Sabha, meeting the Block Development Officer, representing the panchayat at block-level meetings, deciding which development works receive priority, and responding to villagers' complaints. Respondents could identify themselves, themselves with assistance from family members, a family member acting on their behalf, the secretary[12], the former mukhiya, the deputy, or another person. I use these responses to construct a count of functions performed by the mukhiya themselves and a standardised index of exercised authority. A final item asks who has the ultimate say in important decisions.

Results. The median SC mukhiya personally performs four of the five functions, with a mean of 3.6; one-third respondents perform all five. The distribution across functions, however, is more informative than the overall count. 91% reported that they chair the Gram Sabha themselves, while around three-quarters meet government officials, attend block-level meetings, and handle villagers' grievances. Only 47% decide which development works receive priority. The visible and procedural functions of the office tend to remain with the mukhiya, while the allocative function – determining who receives what – is more often exercised by others.

This pattern points to an important limitation of the measure. Chairing a meeting or signing a document is directly observable, whereas decision-making authority is more difficult to capture. A mukhiya may perform each formal function while having limited

[12]The Panchayat Secretary, a salaried government functionary responsible for maintaining records, processing payments, and liaising with the block administration. The secretary reports administratively to the block rather than to the mukhiya, creating scope for tension between the elected officeholder and the administrative apparatus.

influence over the underlying decisions, meaning that the count captures the execution of tasks more reliably than the exercise of substantive control. The final-decision item reveals the same limitation from the opposite direction: 52 percent of respondents report making decisions independently, while only one of the 150 respondents reports that others make decisions entirely on their behalf. The latter figure is difficult to reconcile with the documented prevalence of proxy arrangements, suggesting that respondents may underreport the extent to which their decision-making is constrained or delegated to others.

A second explanation is that proxy arrangements may be sustained by social dominance and the threat of consequences for non-compliance (Heinze 2025). The same fear that sustains these arrangements may also discourage respondents from disclosing them to a stranger over the telephone. More generally, interviewer-administered modes of data collection tend to elicit less disclosure on sensitive matters than self-administered modes (Johnson et al. 1989; Aquilino 1994).

3.2 The forms and prevalence of backlash

Measures. The qualitative interviews identified several distinct forms of obstruction, and I designed the survey instrument to capture these mechanisms separately. Respondents were asked about specific experiences, without using the term backlash or providing a caste-based interpretation of the events. This approach was intended to minimise the extent to which the survey itself imposed the conceptual framework on respondents' accounts.

Backlash may begin before a candidate takes office. Three items therefore ask whether respondents were asked to withdraw their nomination, offered money, land, or other benefits to withdraw or comply, or subjected to threats or intimidation during the election campaign.

For the period in office, I measure five channels through which obstruction or backlash may occur. Four items capture interactions with block-level officials: refusal to meet the mukhiya, unexplained delays in processing files or approvals, withholding information to which the office is entitled, and officials becoming hostile after learning the respondent's caste. Three items capture obstruction within panchayat governance: interference by the former mukhiya, the deputy or secretary acting against the mukhiya's decisions, and ward members[13] refusing to cooperate. Two items capture resistance at the village level: false accusations or cases being filed against the mukhiya, and upper-caste elites

[13] Elected representatives of individual wards within a Gram Panchayat who, together with the mukhiya, constitute the elected panchayat body. Ward members are elected independently and are neither appointed by nor formally accountable to the mukhiya.

mobilising villagers against them. Two items capture symbolic resistance: damage to or opposition against Dr. Ambedkar's statues and other community symbols, and opposition to informing villagers about their rights. Finally, two items capture the most severe forms of backlash: threats against the respondent and physical harm to the respondent or their family.

Ten additional items follow Sue et al.'s (2007) taxonomy of microaggressions. Microinsults capture expressions of surprise that the respondent is capable of performing the duties of office, claims that the position was obtained only through reservation, questioning of the respondent's education or capacity, questioning of their financial standing, and suggestions that someone else should hoist the national flag on ceremonial occasions. Microinvalidations capture instances in which villagers take official matters to the former mukhiya or secretary instead, the respondent's suggestions are disregarded in meetings on the grounds of limited schooling, and the respondent is made to wait longer than upper-caste counterparts at government offices. Microassaults capture differential treatment in relation to food or seating and the use of caste-based slurs. Four additional victim-blaming items assess whether respondents were told that their difficulties were self-inflicted: because they were too assertive, because politics was not meant for people like them, because stepping back would have prevented trouble, or because their problems resulted from a failure to cooperate.

For each reported incident, respondents were asked a follow-up question about its frequency. The module concludes with two summary measures: respondents' assessment of how their treatment compares with that of upper-caste mukhiyas and their assessment of the overall severity of the caste-related difficulties they have experienced.

Results. Backlash is common but unevenly distributed. Just under two-thirds of respondents (64.7%) report experiencing at least one of the twelve in-office forms of backlash, while 22% report five or more, and one respondent reports all twelve. Slightly more than one-third respondents report none. The survey therefore points to a pattern that is not uniform across officeholders but instead reflects concentrated experiences of backlash among a substantial minority.

Pressure before office: Explicit attempts to prevent SC candidates from contesting elections appear to be relatively uncommon. Only four percent of respondents reported being asked to withdraw their nomination, while 6% were offered money, land, or other benefits to withdraw or comply. The proxy-recruitment transaction that features prominently in the qualitative literature and in my interviews appears to be uncommon in this population. Intimidation, by contrast, is more prevalent: 18.7% of respondents reported facing threats during the campaign, approximately three times the rate at

Table 1. Prevalence of reported backlash and microaggression among SC mukhiyas

Item	%	95% CI	n
Theme 1: Bureaucratic roadblocks and institutional gatekeeping			
Kept in the dark about lists or entitled information	15.5	[10.6, 22.2]	148
Officials refused to meet or made them return	14.8	[10.0, 21.3]	149
An official turned hostile on realising their caste	9.3	[5.6, 15.1]	150
Files or approvals delayed without good reason	8.7	[5.2, 14.4]	149
Theme 2: Social microaggressions and symbolic delegitimisation			
Microinsults			
People seemed surprised they can handle the duties	51.3	[43.4, 59.2]	150
Told the position was obtained only through reservation	34.7	[27.5, 42.6]	150
Financial standing to be a leader was questioned	19.3	[13.8, 26.4]	150
Education or capacity for the job was questioned	14.7	[9.9, 21.2]	150
Suggested someone else hoist the flag on national days	4.0	[1.8, 8.5]	150
Microinvalidations			
People took official work to the ex-mukhiya or secretary	14.7	[9.9, 21.2]	150
Made to wait or seated separately, unlike upper castes	13.3	[8.8, 19.7]	150
Suggestions ignored in meetings for lack of schooling	5.3	[2.7, 10.2]	150
Microassaults			
Caste-based slur used against respondent	27.3	[20.8, 35.0]	150
Treated differently over food or seating at a function	8.7	[5.1, 14.3]	150
Theme 3: Elite strategies to maintain control			
Pre-office pressure			
Faced threats or intimidation during the election	18.7	[13.2, 25.7]	150
Offered money, land or benefits to step aside or comply	6.0	[3.2, 11.1]	150
Was asked to withdraw nomination	4.0	[1.8, 8.5]	150
Panchayat-internal			
Ward members or elected members refused to cooperate	36.0	[28.8, 43.9]	150
Former mukhiya interfered with or undermined the work	25.3	[19.0, 32.8]	150
Deputy mukhiya or secretary worked against decisions	16.8	[11.6, 23.6]	149
Community and elite			
False accusations, complaints or cases filed	38.7	[31.2, 46.7]	150
Upper-caste elites tried to organise people against them	24.0	[17.9, 31.4]	150
Theme 4: Resistance to Ambedkar symbols and rights assertion			
Faced opposition for making people aware of their rights	20.7	[15.0, 27.8]	150
Statue or community symbols damaged or opposed	2.7	[1.0, 6.7]	149
Gaslighting / Victim-blaming			
Told politics is not for people like you	24.2	[18.0, 31.6]	149
Told to step back or stay quiet to avoid trouble	17.4	[12.2, 24.3]	149
Told problems are own fault for not cooperating	15.4	[10.5, 22.1]	149
Told troubles were self-inflicted by being too assertive	10.7	[6.7, 16.7]	150
Overt threat and violence			
Received threats because of the work or the caste	14.0	[9.3, 20.5]	150
Respondent or family faced physical harm or violence	12.2	[7.8, 18.4]	148

Notes: Each row reports the share of respondents endorsing the item, with 95% confidence intervals. Items are grouped by the four mechanisms identified in the qualitative pilot. Sample sizes vary between 148 and 150 because respondents who declined an item are treated as missing rather than as negative responses; Items are ordered by prevalence within each panel.

which respondents reported being offered money or other benefits. In one reported episode, respondent's associate faced all the above three measures:

> *"... We fought against all odds and encouraged her to file her nomination. ... We had been standing at the window for a long time to file her papers, so we asked her to stand there while we walked a few metres to get some water. Suddenly, a car arrived, and they put her inside and drove away. It happened within a few seconds. Before we could react, she was gone. We were scared for her safety. A couple hours later, we learned that that upper-caste leader had taken her and her husband to the registrar's office at the block and offered her ₹50,000 and a piece of land in exchange for not filing her nomination. She accepted the offer out of fear, and the land was immediately purchased in her name."*

Bureaucratic roadblocks: Between 8.7% and 15.5% of respondents report experiencing each of the four forms of obstruction, while the median respondent reports none. Being denied access to information about lists and entitlements is the most common (15.5%), followed by officials refusing to meet the mukhiya (14.8%). Unexplained delays in processing files are reported by 8.7%, and 9.3% report that officials became openly hostile after learning their caste. A research participant described how their treatment by local bureaucrats changed after learning their caste identity:

> *"Because of my surname [surname masked], most people assume that I am OBC (Other Backward Class). When they learn that I am scheduled caste, they look at me differently. They do not stand up, they do not show me respect, and they do not offer me a chair to sit on."*

Conditional on occurrence, these experiences are often recurrent rather than isolated: among the 23 respondents who reported being denied information, 17% said this occurred very often, while 23% of the 22 respondents who reported being refused meetings said the same (See Appendix A: Table 5).

Elite strategies inside the panchayat: Obstruction from elected and appointed colleagues is more than twice as common as obstruction from block-level officials. Ward members refusing to cooperate is reported by 36.0% of respondents, while 25.3% report interference by the former mukhiya and 16.8% report that the deputy or secretary worked against their decisions. The former mukhiya is a specific individual with a prior claim to the office, making the finding that one-quarter of respondents continue to experience such interference particularly notable. A study participant described how their work was obstructed:

> *"After a lot of effort, I started a water pipeline project to bring water from a nearby source. It would have provided much-needed relief to the women in our village. But there was opposition to the project, with people claiming that the water was not fit for use. They could not see me succeeding in any*

> *development work or gaining the goodwill of villagers. So, samples were sent for testing. Just one night before the water was to be collected, some people contaminated the water with something. The water test then came back unsatisfactory, and the officials closed the project."*

Elite strategies in the village: False accusations, complaints, or cases filed against the mukhiya are the single most prevalent in-office form of backlash, reported by 38.7% of respondents. Nearly one-quarter (24.0%) report that upper-caste elites organised villagers against them. Both forms of resistance operate through channels that can appear formally legitimate: filing a complaint with the district administration is an institutional act, even when used to obstruct an elected officeholder. Indeed, such complaints constitute the most commonly reported form of backlash among SC mukhiyas. Opposition to rights awareness is also prevalent: 20.7% of respondents report facing resistance when informing villagers about their entitlements.

Microaggressions: These are the most prevalent forms of differential treatment reported in the survey. Just over half of respondents (51.3%) report that others appeared surprised that they could perform the duties of office, while 34.7% have been told that they obtained the position only through reservation. Both experiences are recurrent: among the 52 respondents who reported being told that their position resulted from reservation, 50% said this occurred often or very often. Questioning of respondents' financial standing (19.3%) and education or capacity (14.7%) is less common. Among microassaults, 27.3% report experiencing caste-based slurs and 8.7% report differential treatment in relation to food. Microinvalidations are the least prevalent subtype: 14.7% report that villagers took official matters to the former mukhiya or secretary instead, 13.3% report being made to wait longer than upper-caste counterparts at government offices, and 5.3% report that their suggestions were ignored on the grounds of limited schooling.

Gaslighting: Nearly one-quarter of respondents (24.2%) report being told that politics is not for people like them. Smaller shares were told to step back to avoid trouble (17.4%), that their difficulties were the result of failing to cooperate (15.4%), or that the problems they faced stemmed from being too assertive (10.7%).

Overt threat and violence: Fourteen percent of respondents report receiving threats related to their work or caste, while 12.2% report that they or a family member experienced physical harm. These items represent the most severe forms of the phenomenon examined in this study, yet they are not uncommon. Approximately one in eight SC mukhiyas reports having experienced violence themselves or within their household. The qualitative evidence provides further corroboration of this pattern:

> *"There have been four or five instances when a few drunk men came to my house, abused me, and hurled caste-based slurs at me. They also threw stones at my house. The upper-caste men would not do this themselves; instead, they would incite men from backward-caste or ST communities, give them alcohol, and send them to abuse me at night."*
>
> *"They said, 'We will repeat what happened in Khairlanji*[14] *here if anyone from [caste name masked] supports her. We will chop them up."'*

The two summary measures, however, complicate this picture (See Appendix A: Table 6). When asked how their treatment compares with that of upper-caste mukhiyas, 73.3% report that it is the same, 15.3% that it is better, and only 11.3% that it is worse. Similarly, 54% report experiencing no caste-related difficulties overall, while 63.3% believe that such treatment is never experienced by SC mukhiyas in general. The relationship between these measures is not straightforward, and the available evidence does not permit a definitive interpretation. The specific items ask respondents to report what happened to them, whereas the summary items require them to characterise those experiences explicitly as caste discrimination and to assess whether they are treated worse than an upper-caste counterpart. These are distinct reporting tasks. A mukhiya may report experiencing a caste slur, a false case, and refusal by ward members to cooperate, while still not describing their overall treatment as worse than that of an upper-caste mukhiya. This may be because such treatment is perceived as a routine feature of holding office rather than a departure from the expected conditions of office.

3.3 Does exercised authority predict backlash?

Measures. The central claim examined in this study is that SC mukhiyas who exercise greater independent authority experience more backlash than those who exercise less. I test this observable implication by regressing each standardised backlash index on the standardised authority index. I progressively add covariates in five specifications, beginning with individual demographics, followed by panchayat characteristics, political background and knowledge, and finally district fixed effects. The regression specification is as follows:

$$B_{id} \;=\; \beta\, A_{id} \;+\; \boldsymbol{X}'_{id}\,\gamma \;+\; \delta_d \;+\; \varepsilon_{id} \tag{3.1}$$

[14] A village in Maharashtra where, in September 2006, four members of a Dalit family were murdered by dominant-caste (Kunbi) villagers following a land dispute. The case became a prominent reference point in public discussions of caste violence and atrocity; respondents invoked it as shorthand for the potential escalation of dominant-caste retaliation (Teltumbde 2011).

Results. The association between exercised authority and reported backlash is small, imprecisely estimated, and unstable in sign. In the full specification, the coefficients are -0.085 for microaggression exposure, $+0.028$ for bureaucratic backlash, $+0.010$ for social and elite backlash, and -0.026 for pooled backlash. None is statistically distinguishable from zero at conventional levels, and none exceeds one-tenth of a standard deviation in magnitude. Adding district fixed effects reverses the sign of the microaggression coefficient. With standard errors of approximately 0.10, the design has sufficient precision to detect associations of roughly 0.28 standard deviations or larger. The estimates therefore place a bound on what can be inferred from the data: if exercised authority is associated with backlash in this population, the association is smaller than the study is sufficiently powered to detect.

I do not interpret these estimates as evidence of no relationship, for three reasons. First, measurement error in the authority index is likely to weaken any true association towards zero, and the preceding section provides direct reasons to expect such error. Second, the problem of reverse causality: two mechanisms may operate simultaneously in opposite directions. Greater assertion of authority may provoke backlash, while backlash may, in turn, suppress the exercise of authority. Their effects may therefore offset one another, producing an association close to zero even when both mechanisms exist. Third, the observational design cannot distinguish between these mechanisms because both variables are measured at the same point in time and reported by the same respondent. This marks the limit of what the observational data can establish and motivates the experiment presented in the following section.

3.4 Stated preferences over hypothetical counterparts

Measures. The observational results cannot distinguish between two potentially opposing processes: independent assertion of authority provoking backlash and backlash suppressing the exercise of authority, because both are measured at the same point in time. The conjoint addresses this problem by experimentally manipulating the hypothesised trigger. Each of the 149 non-SC respondents evaluated five pairs of hypothetical mukhiyas, whose profiles varied along four independently randomised attributes: caste (scheduled caste with probability 0.5, and Yadav or Rajput otherwise), authority style (takes decisions independently or follows established elders and former mukhiyas), economic position, and education. For each pair, respondents indicated which mukhiya they would find easier to cooperate with on a shared block-level matter and which they would prefer as the mukhiya of their own panchayat. The AMCE and interaction specifications are as follows:

Table 2. Association between de facto authority and reported backlash

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	MDE
Outcome	Bivariate	+ Demog.	+ Panchayat	+ Politics	+ District FE	(SD)
Regressor: de facto authority index						
Microaggression	−0.049	−0.059	−0.056	−0.085	0.044	0.28
	(0.080)	(0.107)	(0.107)	(0.109)	(0.170)	
Bureaucratic backlash	0.047	0.056	0.050	0.028	0.028	0.26
	(0.065)	(0.081)	(0.086)	(0.098)	(0.128)	
Social and elite backlash	0.075	0.045	0.008	0.010	0.031	0.32
	(0.089)	(0.113)	(0.113)	(0.118)	(0.147)	
Backlash, all channels	0.032	0.020	−0.008	−0.026	−0.025	—
	(0.075)	(0.105)	(0.104)	(0.113)	(0.143)	
Victim-blaming	−0.064	−0.045	−0.082	−0.095	−0.051	0.33
	(0.093)	(0.117)	(0.120)	(0.124)	(0.175)	

Notes:: Ordinary least squares with heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors in parentheses. All outcomes are standardised indices, so coefficients are in standard deviation units. Covariates enter cumulatively: (2) adds age, education, terms served, times stood for election and family political background; (3) adds panchayat population, SC population share, revenue villages, main-village status, household income and party support; (4) adds the knowledge index and an indicator for a proxy respondent; (5) adds district fixed effects. The MDE column reports the minimum detectable effect implied by the standard error in specification (4) at 80% power. Sample sizes range from 148 to 150. * p < 0.10.

$$Y_{ijk} \;=\; \sum_{c\in\{\text{SC, Rajput}\}} \alpha_c\, \mathbf{1}(Caste_{ijk}=c) \;+\; \beta\, Indep_{ijk} \;+\; \gamma\, Econ_{ijk} \;+\; \lambda\, Educ_{ijk} \;+\; \epsilon_{ijk} \tag{3.2}$$

$$Y_{ijk} \;=\; \beta_1\, SC_{ijk} \;+\; \beta_2\, Indep_{ijk} \;+\; \beta_3 \left(SC_{ijk} \times Indep_{ijk}\right) \;+\; \boldsymbol{W}'_{ijk}\,\boldsymbol{\theta} \;+\; \epsilon_{ijk} \tag{3.3}$$

Cooperation is the pre-specified primary outcome because it captures the everyday working relationships at the centre of this study, whereas the election outcome may introduce respondents' own succession interests into their responses. I estimate average marginal component effects (AMCEs) using OLS on the stacked profile data, with standard errors clustered at the respondent level. The pre-specified primary hypothesis concerns the interaction between scheduled caste and independent authority style.

Results. The results run against the study's hypothesis. Scheduled Caste profiles are chosen more often, rather than less. Relative to an otherwise identical Yadav profile, an SC profile is 11.5 pp more likely to be selected as easier to cooperate with (95% CI: 4.8–18.1). The corresponding estimate relative to a Rajput profile is 10.9 pp, while

Table 3. Conjoint experiment: average marginal component effects

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
	Cooperation	Election	Alt. reference	+ Position
Scheduled Caste	0.115***	0.117***	0.109***	0.114***
	(0.034)	(0.033)	(0.034)	(0.033)
Rajput	0.006	0.011	—	0.005
	(0.038)	(0.038)		(0.038)
Yadav	—	—	−0.006	—
			(0.038)	
Takes decisions independently	0.124***	0.138***	0.124***	0.124***
	(0.035)	(0.036)	(0.035)	(0.035)
Well-off and landowning	−0.041	−0.044*	−0.041	−0.041
	(0.026)	(0.026)	(0.026)	(0.026)
Well educated	0.174***	0.171***	0.174***	0.174***
	(0.027)	(0.027)	(0.027)	(0.027)
Second profile in pair	—	—	—	−0.009
				(0.040)
Constant	0.314***	0.307***	0.319***	0.319***
	(0.034)	(0.032)	(0.036)	(0.037)
Profile observations	1,490	1,490	1,490	1,490
Respondents	149	149	149	149
R^2	0.061	0.064	0.061	0.061

Notes: Ordinary least squares on stacked profile data, with standard errors clustered by respondent in parentheses. The outcome is an indicator for the profile being selected. Column (1) is the pre-specified primary outcome (which profile the respondent would find easier to cooperate with on a shared block-level matter); column (2) is the secondary outcome (which the respondent would prefer as mukhiya of their own panchayat); column (3) re-estimates column (1) with Rajput rather than Yadav as the omitted caste level; column (4) adds an indicator for the profile being read second. Caste was drawn with unequal probabilities (0.50 Scheduled Caste, 0.25 Yadav, 0.25 Rajput), so precision differs across caste levels. Approximate minimum detectable effects are 12.0 pp for the Scheduled Caste coefficient and 15.0 pp for authority style. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

the two dominant-caste profiles are statistically indistinguishable from one another. The secondary outcome yields a similar estimate of 11.7 pp, and controlling for profile position leaves the estimate essentially unchanged. Independent authority style is also preferred, increasing the probability of being selected by 12.4 pp. Education has the largest overall effect, at 17.4 pp, while wealth has a small negative coefficient that does not reach conventional levels of statistical significance.

The interaction points in the same direction (See Appendix A: Table 7). Among profiles that follow established elders and former mukhiyas, the SC profile has a 6.9 pp advantage, while among profiles that take decisions independently, the advantage increases to 15.3 pp. The difference between these two estimates, 8.4 pp, is the pre-specified test of the interaction. However, it falls below the 14.4 pp minimum detectable effect (MDE) and its 95% confidence interval (−2.1 to 19.0) includes zero. I therefore cannot distinguish the estimated interaction from no difference.

Heterogeneity by prejudice does not support a simpler result (See Appendix A: Table 8). Respondents below the median on the prejudice index show a 22.5 pp preference for independent SC profiles, while those above the median show a preference of around 9 pp regardless of authority style. The triple interaction is −5.9 pp, compared with a minimum detectable effect of 20.4 pp. The estimate is therefore too imprecise to support a strong conclusion and, if anything, runs against the direction predicted by a straightforward prejudice-based account.

I do not interpret these estimates as evidence that non-SC mukhiyas favour independent SC leaders. I can think of two possible explanations for this counterintuitive result. First, the caste attribute in the profile may have been salient in a different way: for a non-SC mukhiya, a scheduled caste counterpart in a neighbouring panchayat may be perceived as the easier partner precisely because the existing social hierarchy makes it more likely that disagreements will be resolved in the respondent's favour, whereas a Yadav or Rajput counterpart may be expected to negotiate from a position of greater parity.

Second, before the conjoint experiment, the instrument asked respondents eleven explicit questions about SC mukhiyas, making the subject of the study apparent. Expressing a preference for the SC profile may therefore have been the socially desirable response, particularly because the estimated premium is largest for the most sympathetic profile and among respondents who report the lowest scores of prejudice index. Set against the descriptive evidence, in which 39% of SC mukhiyas report having false complaints filed against them and 36% report elected colleagues refusing to cooperate, the divergence between what non-SC mukhiyas say about hypothetical counterparts and what SC mukhiyas report about their actual experiences is itself informative. The experiment therefore establishes a narrower result than originally intended: in stated preferences over hypothetical peers, respondents express no caste penalty against SC mukhiyas.

3.5 Do non-SC leaders penalise independent SC counterparts?

Measures. The conjoint asks respondents to choose between profiles but does not require them to bear any cost. To examine whether these stated preferences extend to a willingness to incur a cost, I included a within-subject cash-burning exercise based on the design logic of Cullen et al. (2024), with hypothetical rather than real stakes. Each respondent evaluated four prospective mukhiyas, presented one at a time in randomised order and described only by caste and authority style: an SC candidate who acts independently, an SC candidate who follows established elders, a candidate from the respondent's own caste who acts independently, and a candidate from the respondent's own caste who follows established elders. For each profile, respondents were asked how much, if anything, of the ₹100,000 prize money they would spend to reduce that candidate's chances of becoming mukhiya. Cash-burning experiment specification:

$$A_{ij} \;=\; \alpha_i \;+\; b_1\, SC_j \;+\; b_2\, Indep_j \;+\; b_3 \left(SC_j \times Indep_j \right) \;+\; \boldsymbol{\lambda}' Slot_{ij} \;+\; u_{ij} \tag{3.4}$$

Because every respondent evaluated all four profiles, respondent fixed effects absorb individual differences in generosity, scale use, and willingness to engage with the task. The estimand of interest is the interaction between caste and authority style: the additional amount respondents would spend to reduce the chances of an SC candidate becoming mukhiya when that candidate acts independently, relative to when they follow established elders and former mukhiyas. This is estimated as a within-respondent difference-in-differences.

Results. Most respondents declined to spend any of the prize money. Across all 596 profile observations, the median amount spent is zero, 81.5% of responses are zero, and the mean of ₹11,242 is driven almost entirely by a small group at the upper end of the distribution: 7.2% of responses allocate the full ₹100,000, while a further 4.0% allocate half. More importantly, 65.8% of respondents assigned the same amount to all four profiles. Thus, approximately two-thirds of the sample provides no within-respondent variation, leaving the estimates identified by the 51 respondents who differentiated between profiles.

Among respondents who allocated any amount, caste makes little difference. Mean allocations are ₹12,584 for the independent SC profile, ₹11,175 for the independent own-caste profile, ₹10,805 for the compliant SC profile, and ₹10,403 for the compliant own-caste profile. Although the ordering is consistent with the hypothesis, the differences are small: the gap between the two extreme cells is less than ₹2,200 on a ₹100,000 scale. On the extensive margin, caste has no discernible effect. The share of respondents willing to spend anything is 20.1% for both independent profiles and 16.8% for both compliant profiles, with no difference by caste.

The fixed-effects estimates reinforce this pattern. Respondents would spend ₹325 more against a compliant SC profile than against a compliant own-caste profile (95% CI: −₹3,950 to ₹4,601), and ₹1,338 more against an independent SC profile (95% CI: −₹3,795 to ₹6,472). The estimated amplification effect - the difference between these

Table 4. Cash burning experiment

Panel A. Amounts by profile ($n = 149$ per profile)

Profile	Mean (₹)	SD (₹)	Median (₹)	Spent > 0 (%)
SC, acts independently	12 584	29 106	0	20.1
Own caste, acts independently	11 175	27 110	0	20.1
SC, follows elders	10 805	28 741	0	16.8
Own caste, follows elders	10 403	27 751	0	16.8
All profiles	11 242	28 129	0	18.5

Panel B. Respondent fixed-effects estimates

	Estimate (₹)	Std. error	95% CI	p
SC, compliant (b_1)	325	(2,164)	[−3,950, 4,601]	0.881
Acts independently (b_2)	750	(3,247)	[−5,667, 7,167]	0.818
Amplification (b_3)	1 013	(3,494)	[−5,892, 7,917]	0.772
SC, independent ($b_1 + b_3$)	1 338	(2,598)	[−3,795, 6,472]	0.607

Panel C. Diagnostics

	Count	%
Responses of ₹0	486 of 596	81.5
Responses of the full ₹100,000	43 of 596	7.2
Respondents giving all four the same amount	98 of 149	65.8
Joint test of slot position: $F = 0.82$, $p = 0.483$		

Notes: Respondents were asked to imagine a prize of ₹100,000 and to state how much of it, if any, they would spend to reduce each of four prospective mukhiyas' chances of taking office. All four profiles were shown to every respondent in randomised order. Panel B reports estimates from a specification with respondent fixed effects and indicators for presentation slot, with standard errors clustered by respondent; b_3 is a within-respondent difference in differences. Because 65.8% of respondents assigned an identical amount to all four profiles, the fixed-effects estimates are identified from the 51 respondents who discriminated between them. Expressed against the realised standard deviation of the within-respondent difference in differences (₹36,802), the amplification effect corresponds to 0.027 SD, against a minimum detectable effect of 0.23 SD (₹8,447). The comparison profile was described as belonging to the respondent's own caste rather than a named caste, so the caste contrast conflates hostility toward Scheduled Castes with ordinary in-group preference.

two caste contrasts - is ₹1,013 (95% CI: $-$₹5,892 to ₹7,917). Relative to the realised standard deviation of the within-respondent difference-in-differences, this corresponds to 0.027 SD, approximately one-eighth of the 0.23 SD minimum detectable effect for which the design was powered.

The two experiments fail in different ways: the forced-choice conjoint experiment requires respondents to select one profile, and the socially desirable response may be to select the SC profile. The cash-burning task allows respondents to opt out of expressing a preference through spending, and four in five respondents chose not to spend anything. What the two tasks share is a setting in which respondents are aware of the subject being examined and may therefore have reasons to withhold their candid preferences.

CHAPTER 4

Conclusion

4.1 Conclusion

I set out to examine how the exercise of independent authority by scheduled caste mukhiyas relates to the backlash they encounter. The evidence supports a narrower conclusion than the question initially posed, and the reasons for this limitation are themselves informative. What the survey establishes most clearly is prevalence. Just under two-thirds of SC mukhiyas in Bihar report at least one form of obstruction or exclusion, while around one-fifth report five or more. To my knowledge, no previous study has systematically measured the prevalence of these practices among SC mukhiyas. Existing evidence on Dalit officeholders draws largely on individual village case studies, women-only samples, and reports outside peer-reviewed research (Lele, 2001; PRIA, 2003; Mangubhai et al., 2009; Kumar, 2025; Deeksha, 2023). These accounts converge in documenting such practices, but do not establish how widespread they are. The survey shows that they are common.

Purohit (2026) identifies the block office as a potential source of obstruction, providing evidence that BDOs rank SC profiles lowest in perceived effectiveness. In this study, however, block-level obstruction is the least prevalent of the five channels measured. Resistance instead comes from closer to the office itself: ward members refusing to cooperate, false complaints being filed with the district administration, and former mukhiyas continuing to interfere years after leaving office. Moreover, the most common form of backlash is an act that is formally legitimate. This extends a pattern already visible in the literature, in which the no-confidence motion reappears as a preferred instrument of resistance (Lele, 2001; PRIA, 2003; Mangubhai et al., 2009).

The most consequential finding is a discrepancy between respondents' accounts of specific incidents and their broader characterisation of those experiences. Only 11% report being treated worse than an upper-caste mukhiya, while 54% report experiencing no caste-related difficulties at all. One reason could be that respondents were reluctant to describe their treatment in explicitly caste-based terms when speaking to a stranger over the telephone (Johnson et al. 1989). Mansbridge and Shames (2008) suggest another possibility: their distinction between power as capacity and coercive power implies that where dominance operates as capacity, it may require no observable act and therefore produce no discrete event that can be readily identified as backlash.

Neither experiment answered the question for which it was designed. Non-SC mukhiyas selected SC profiles more often, rather than less often, and did not burn more money to reduce SC profiles' chances of winning. I interpret these findings as more likely reflecting limitations of measurement than providing evidence about elite dispositions. The contrast with Purohit (2026) is suggestive in this regard: her BDO respondents, when asked to assess effectiveness rather than willingness to cooperate, ranked SC profiles last. The divergence may reflect differences in the populations studied, the outcomes elicited, or the fact that my respondents had already answered eleven explicit questions about caste before the experiments began. Distinguishing among these explanations would require a design that conceals the subject of the study more effectively than mine did.

I see two implications from this study. The first is that backlash against SC mukhiyas may not be primarily a bureaucratic phenomenon; interventions focused on the block office therefore may target the least prevalent channel identified in the data. The second is interpretive: Flood et al. (2020) and Haider-Markel (2007) argue that gains and backlash of empowerment measures are often produced together, such that the absence of backlash may indicate that little has been redistributed. Political quotas can redistribute resources (Pande 2003; Besley et al. 2004; Chattopadhyay and Duflo 2004), and the backlash experienced by these mukhiyas may instead reflect the costs of that redistribution.

4.2 Limitations and further research

This study was designed and conducted within the resource and time constraints of a master's dissertation. Some limitations follow directly from these constraints and could be addressed in a better-resourced follow-up study; others are design choices that I would revise in light of the findings.

The main limitation of this study is statistical power. With 150 SC and 149 non-SC respondents, the experiments could detect only relatively large caste-by-authority effects, and the estimated effects fell well within these detection limits. A substantially larger sample would provide the precision needed to test the central hypothesis more rigorously. A second limitation concerns measurement. The conjoint and cash-burning experiments followed eleven explicit questions about attitudes towards SC mukhiyas, likely making the study's purpose salient before the experiments began. Placing the experiments earlier or using a design that better concealed the object of interest would have reduced this risk; this is a sequencing choice I would revise in future research.

A third limitation concerns the non-SC sample. Ideally, I would have sampled dominant-caste elites from the same panchayats as the SC respondents, but no sampling frame exists for this population, and constructing one was beyond the scope of the study. I therefore sampled serving non-SC mukhiyas from the same state register, assuming that their attitudes approximate those of the elites encountered by SC mukhiyas. This assumption is plausible but untested and may not hold, as sitting mukhiyas have institutional interests that other local elites may not share. A fourth limitation concerns the authority measure. The five task-locus items capture who performs particular functions, which may differ from who ultimately controls decisions; the contrast between the 91% who chair Gram Sabha meetings and the 47% who set development priorities illustrates this limitation. A stronger measure would combine village-level observation of where allocative decisions are made with cognitive interviewing to validate survey items. Fifth limitation: Telephone administration may be poorly suited to measuring discrimination, as interviewer-administered modes can reduce disclosure on sensitive topics (Johnson et al. 1989).

Finally, the survey contains no measures of gender-specific backlash. This omission followed from the design choice of restricting the qualitative interviews to men, and it means that the instrument cannot capture the intersectional forms of backlash experienced by SC women mukhiyas. A couple of SC women presidents described the kind of backlash they experienced:

> *"I did not have a vehicle, so I used to travel with our panchayat secretary on his motorcycle to attend meetings at the block level. Those people started spreading rumours about me and questioning my character. Since my husband worked away from home, they would call him and make allegations that I was unfaithful. Fortunately, my husband trusted me completely and never questioned my integrity."*

> *"A vegetable seller overheard Santosh Patil [pseudonym; a young supporter of a local Maratha[15] strongman] abusing me and saying, 'Raand kuthli' ('What a prostitute she is'). He said, 'One day I will catch her alone, sleep with her, and impregnate her. Maratha ahe mi ('I am a Maratha!').'"*

In future research, I intend to systematically study the intersectional dimensions of elite backlash.

[15] A numerically and politically influential landowning caste in Maharashtra, with a historically disproportionate presence in elected office and cooperative institutions.

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APPENDIX A

Additional Statistics and Analyses

Table 5. Frequency of occurrence, among respondents reporting the item

Item	n	Rarely	Sometimes	Often	Very often
Microinsults					
Surprise that he can handle the duties	77	16.9	45.5	11.7	24.7
Position obtained only through reservation	52	9.6	38.5	21.2	28.8
Financial standing questioned	29	20.7	37.9	13.8	27.6
Education or capacity questioned	22	31.8	40.9	4.5	22.7
Someone else should hoist the flag	6	0.0	66.7	16.7	16.7
Microassaults					
Treated differently over food or seating	13	7.7	46.2	7.7	38.5
Made to wait or seated separately	20	20.0	40.0	5.0	35.0
Bureaucratic obstruction					
Officials refused to meet	22	36.4	31.8	9.1	22.7
Files or approvals delayed	13	38.5	38.5	0.0	23.1
Kept in the dark about lists or information	23	30.4	43.5	8.7	17.4
Official turned hostile on realising caste	14	21.4	50.0	7.1	14.3

Notes: Percentages are of respondents who reported experiencing the item, so the denominator differs by row. Frequency follow-ups were asked only for the microinsult, microassault and bureaucratic obstruction blocks. Rows may not sum to 100 because a small number of respondents reported the incident but declined to give a frequency.

Table 6. Summary measures of comparative treatment, severity and perceived prevalence

Response category	Frequency	Percent (%)
Treatment relative to upper-caste mukhiyas (n = 150)		
A lot better	12	8.00
Better	11	7.33
The same	110	73.33
Somewhat worse	16	10.67
Much worse	1	0.67
Reporting worse treatment	17	11.3
Overall severity of caste-related difficulties (n = 149)		
None	81	54.36
Mild	30	20.13
Moderate	11	7.38
Severe	17	11.41
Very severe	10	6.71
Perceived prevalence among SC mukhiyas generally (n = 150)		
Never	95	63.33
Rare	27	18.00
Somewhat common	11	7.33
Very common	17	11.33

Notes: The three items were asked at the end of the module. The share reporting worse treatment combines the somewhat worse and much worse categories. The severity item was not compulsory, so one response is missing and is excluded rather than coded as none.

Table 7. Conjoint experiment: marginal means by caste and authority style

Profile caste	Follows elites	Independent	Difference
Cooperation outcome (all respondents)			
Yadav or Rajput	0.404	0.487	0.084
	(0.026)	(0.026)	(0.044)
Scheduled Caste	0.473	0.641	0.168
	(0.028)	(0.025)	(0.038)
SC premium	0.069	0.153	0.084

Notes: Predicted probability of being selected as the easier counterpart to cooperate with, with standard errors in parentheses. Because the outcome is a forced choice between two profiles, the marginal means are centred on 0.5 by construction and identify relative rather than absolute preference. The most-preferred cell is the independently acting Scheduled Caste profile and the least-preferred is the deferential dominant-caste profile.

Table 8. Conjoint experiment: heterogeneity by prejudice

	Estimate	Std. error	p
Panel A. Continuous moderation, cooperation outcome			
Scheduled Caste	0.078	(0.040)	0.051
Takes decisions independently	0.083	(0.046)	0.073
SC × independent	0.080	(0.054)	0.140
Prejudice index	0.014	(0.029)	0.636
SC × prejudice	−0.016	(0.044)	0.716
Independent × prejudice	0.013	(0.046)	0.776
SC × independent × prejudice	−0.059	(0.053)	0.267

Panel B. Split-sample marginal means	*Follows elders*	*Independent*	*SC premium*
Below-median prejudice (690 profile observations)			
Yadav or Rajput	0.417	0.445	
Scheduled Caste	0.475	0.670	
SC premium	0.058	0.225	0.168
Above-median prejudice (700 profile observations)			
Yadav or Rajput	0.385	0.526	
Scheduled Caste	0.485	0.615	
SC premium	0.100	0.090	−0.010

Notes: The prejudice index is the first principal component of the eleven-item attitude battery, standardised and oriented so that higher values indicate more prejudice; its sign was fixed a priori by anchoring on the item asserting that reserved-seat mukhiyas are less capable. Panel A treats the moderator as continuous; Panel B splits at the median of prejudice index. Ten respondents are missing the prejudice index and drop from both panels. This analysis is exploratory: simulation using the realised design puts the minimum detectable subgroup difference in the interaction above 35 pp, so no estimate here can support a conclusion, and the sign should not be interpreted on its own.

Table 9. Power and minimum detectable effects

Quantity	Realised MDE
SC mukhiya survey	
Single prevalence estimate, 95% CI half-width at $p = 0.5$	$\pm$8.0 pp
Smallest detectable correlation, $n = 150$	$r = 0.23$
Authority coefficient on backlash indices	0.26–0.33 SD
Across both samples	
SC versus non-SC comparison, standardised index	0.32 SD
Conjoint experiment	
Scheduled Caste AMCE	12.0 pp
Authority-style AMCE	15.0 pp
Caste $\times$ authority interaction	25.0 pp
Interaction difference across prejudice subgroups	>35.0 pp
Cash-burning experiment	
Within-respondent difference-in-differences	0.23 SD (₹8,447)

Notes: The minimum detectable effect is the smallest true effect the design would detect with 80% power at a two-sided significance level of 0.05. Figures are computed from the realised samples and variances rather than from the sample sizes anticipated before fieldwork. Survey and comparison quantities use the standard analytical formulae; the conjoint figures come from simulation on the realised attribute assignments and cluster structure, and the cash-burning figure from the realised standard deviation of the within-respondent difference-in-differences. pp denotes percentage points and SD standard deviations of the relevant index. An MDE is not a threshold below which an estimate is meaningless: it states what the design could and could not have detected, and is reported here so that the magnitude of each estimate in Chapter 3 (Results and Discussion) can be read against it.